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Heavyweight Bout: Traditional Publicity vs. Content Marketing



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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You have countless options when it comes to marketing your company. You could run a TV ad, put up a billboard, or hand out fliers. You could create a blog and curate it with quality content and engage with reader comments. You could choose to focus only on outbound marketing or only on inbound or a mix of both.

Traditional publicity falls in the outbound marketing camp. This is when you reach out to the public without requiring any interaction from them before presenting your pitch. For example, you might not subscribe to cable television, but you've probably seen numerous advertisements for programming on the Lifetime channel on billboards around town (especially if you live in LA).

Then there's inbound marketing, and its cornerstone: content marketing. This is when you curate a blog filled with valuable content among other forms of passive media (podcasts, videos, etc). This form of marketing requires the public to bite on a well-ranked search result that satisfies their search request. Or maybe that post was uploaded to any number of social media platforms and attracted attention.

Each marketing camp has its ardent supporters. Some swear by the time-tested outbound techniques. Others

have found great success with the relatively new inbound methods. So here are the high-level benefits and drawbacks to both forms of marketing your company.



Traditional Publicity

Publicizing a company's message has been a part of society dating back to pre-Vesuvius [Pompeii](#). The methods are tried and true, but can be time consuming, costly and come with a minimal return.

Using outbound marketing is similar to casting a wide net. You know members of your target demo live in West Hollywood, so that is where you put your billboard. Countless people pass your advertisement every day without taking notice, but you take that chance because a few members of your target market will see it and hopefully convert into leads.

Measuring the returns on traditional publicity can be difficult and often requires ham-fisted questionnaires requesting your customers explain how they heard about your company, product or service. Other than that, often only [broad generalizations](#) about increased sales can be attributed to traditional publicity's effectiveness.



Content Marketing

A more surgical approach to advertising is inbound marketing with content marketing leading the charge. The comparative cost is minimal since you're using the strength of your brand coupled with tailored content to appeal to your target market. You can create a compelling piece of content, or a how-to that draws your audience to you through their own searches. This method is in stark contrast to erecting billboards or running ads on television.

The expectation is your target market will be searching for exactly what you are offering. With your expertly crafted content leveraging SEO techniques and offering an emotionally compelling hook, you may find your target audience lining up to convert.

Inbound marketing also provides far more statistical data than traditional publicity, which allows you to analyze what grabs your target market's attention and what doesn't.



Word of Mouth

Word of mouth is a naturally occurring common ground between all forms of publicity. This phenomenon can generate interest beyond the scope of your efforts with both inbound and outbound marketing.

Some marketers call this phenomenon going viral. Rampant sharing of your content via social media has become the modern-day equivalent of people chatting up your brand to their friends. Both outbound and inbound marketing can create a swell of public interest and the potential to go viral.

But, as they say, don't hold your breath. You cannot engineer virality with any real percentage of success. This, of course, hasn't stopped [many from trying](#). Worse still, your audience may smell a disingenuous attempt to trick them into sharing your content. You surely have seen countless shared articles with desperate titles that include phrases like: You won't believe what happens next! Or, 10 things you're doing wrong at this moment.

With that said, there are many ardent supporters of cultivating a strong verbal buzz. In a recent Bloomberg

BusinessWeek debate on word of mouth advertising [effectiveness](#), Shawn P. O'Connor of Stratus Prep says "Word of mouth has been the driver of my company's success, translating into hundreds of new business referrals each year."

Infographic

The digital analytics consulting firm Attach Media compiled an infographic outlining the high-level differences between traditional publicity vs. content marketing. [Attach Media](#) suggests that traditional publicity's main goal is to interrupt those passing the advertisement, where content marketing's main goal is to inform.

Takeaway

If your goal is to grow your business, both traditional publicity and content marketing can help you do this. If you have the budget to promote your company through traditional advertising avenues like TV ads and billboards, you may find success. However, traditional publicity is costly and lacks the comparative conversion effectiveness of content marketing. If you are marketing a service or product on a budget, you may be better served by focusing on inbound marketing and producing compelling content.

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BIO

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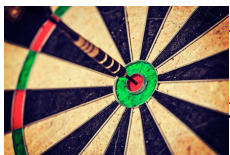
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